

RBI compromised by Russian ISP

The Bank of India's website was infected with malware by an illegal Russian ISP by the name of RBN



BSNL top ISP

BSNL is the leader amongst Indian ISPs, with a 43% market share

Private ISPs

Although these are still few and far between, private ISPs in India have packages that are competitively priced

Feature

IPTV

A relatively new entrant into the world of internet services in India, Internet Protocol Television is a triple-play bundled service which offers broadband internet connections, digital television, VoIP and Video on Demand services – all over a single connection.

WiMAX

WiMAX stands for worldwide interoperability for microwave access and is a wireless technology that allows broadband access, usually for WiFi hot spots and providing 'last-mile-connectivity'. WiMAX promises cheaper, faster wireless access, but having been introduced in India only in 2009, has yet to make its presence properly felt.

How to choose an ISP

Which of these technologies you choose depends on several factors. If you travel a lot, need to access the web on the go or can't stop tweeting your friends, you'll have to depend on the GSM or CDMA internet access services provided by your cellular service provider. Or, if you're living in a city, you could use your laptop at any of the Wi-Fi hubs that are fast increasing in number. Mobile telephony companies (such as Reliance, Tata and Idea) offer USB modems that can be used with your laptop (and your PC too), which doesn't leave you dependent on a Wi-Fi zone. However, you need to be within their network coverage. If you have a static PC to work with, DSL would be one of the better options to choose.

- **Speed:** A high-speed connection is essential to almost anyone who bothers to log on to the net today. Although the basic minimum is 256 kbps for broadband, it's not always what the ISP says it is. The speed of connection that you actually experience will often be a far cry from that promised by the ISP. The number quoted to you is the maximum possible – but not always what you get in reality.

- **Upload/download limits:** Typically, an ISP offers you cheaper deals for limited usage. So the 1 GB scheme with speed 256 kbps would be the cheapest while the 'Unlimited' ones with speeds of 2 Mbps or 16 Mbps would be most expensive. If you just want to check your email once or twice a day, check up the odd web page or download a few documents in Word or PDF, the 1-GB or 2-GB limit would do just fine.

Most ISPs have some form of an unlimited plan on offer. Sometimes, this is bundled up with the regular low-tariff plans as "free unlimited night surfing". However, there's a catch. Different ISPs

have different concepts of "night". Some give you the happy hours from 8 p.m. to 8 a.m., others from 10 p.m. to 8 a.m. while some from 2 a.m. to 8 a.m. only. So either you'll need to get up really early in the morning or stay awake late if you want to take advantage of these. This, however, is great for those of you who just can't stop downloading, but are too busy working through the day to log on and find your favourite videos. 1 GB bandwidth, however, gets exhausted pretty quickly even if you're not downloading heavy files in the daytime. Flash files, online radio, etc., also use up a lot of bandwidth, so perhaps you'd do better opting for 2 GB or 4 GB plans with 'night-unlimited' combos.

"Unlimited" isn't really unlimited either. Taking inspiration from the international ISPs, some Indian companies (viz. Airtel and Tata Indicom) recently announced a limit on their 'unlimited' plans. The unlimited high-speed access to the web is now restricted to 20 GB or 50 GB, or more, depending on the company and the scheme. If you exceed this limit, the ISP may do any of two things: (a) It may halve the speed of data transfer to your PC, or (b) It may even terminate your account. They call this the "Fair

Use Policy" – an internationally accepted term which refers to a metering system or a restriction on individual use of bandwidth so that a single user does not hog all of it, leaving little or nothing for others. If you're looking, you'll find the details in really fine print.

- **Reliability:** It would be of great help to you if you could figure out the latency trends of a particular ISP. 'Latency' refers to delay in data transmission. The amount of time a packet of data takes to

reach from one point in a network to another could be greatly affected by faulty hardware, congestion in the network or crashing servers.

- **Service/Maintenance:** Got a glitch with your modem? Can't login because of a virus? Being overcharged? Don't expect your favourite ISP personnel to barge into your home with instant solutions. It may take them anything from a few hours to a few days. Most disconcerting is the advice you receive from the call-centre executive, who puts you through mundane motions and IP checks while the problem very clearly lies elsewhere. Again, find out from your kith and kin how customer support and tech support of a particular ISP is before you go and purchase your first connection. Better still, find out the customer helpline and make a call yourself to see what kind of reply you receive – or whether you receive a reply at all.

- **The fine print:** In the age of the internet, it's amazing that the ISPs still expect us to read extremely small fonts at the end of the forms we're supposed to fill. Typically, however,

we don't read the 'Terms and Conditions' section even if the print is big enough for our impatient eyes. We forget that the reason that the terms are in fine print is precisely because if we read them, we'd probably never apply for a connection at all. Here are a few points you should keep in mind about the fine print:

- ◆ An asterisk (*) usually refers to a crimp in the scheme. Check out what it says.
- ◆ Never trust the word "free". Nothing comes free, especially bandwidth. A leading ISP offered two months of free dialup internet services to existing phone users in 2008. Users who failed to read the fine print didn't realise that while internet access was free, usage was charged according to the pulse rate of a regular phone call. Expectedly, several users were shocked to receive unbelievable bills, only to be told that the error was theirs.
- ◆ Not all rates printed by ISPs in their offer documents are inclusive of service tax.
- ◆ The ISP retains the full right to revise tariffs of all existing schemes without notice.
- ◆ Every ISP has the right to terminate any customer's connection without any notice if it finds the customer defaulting on a payment, misusing the services or sending unsolicited messages.
- ◆ The ISP does not provide any warranty that they will provide "an uninterrupted and error free service".
- ◆ The ISP takes no responsibility of the sites you browse and whatever you access is at your own risk. You can't, for example, file a case against your ISP for not installing an effective firewall or for allowing malicious software to enter your PC.
- ◆ "Unlimited" always means "Limited". The trick words here are "up to" (or, as in some cases, the misspelling "upto"). Try and find out what the limit on the 'unlimited' is before signing up.
- ◆ ISPs can block the viewing of certain web sites or blogs, read your email or terminate your service at any given time without notice. An example of this is the selective blocking of certain internet telephony sites by some Indian ISPs before net telephony was legalised in April 2002.

While we can't enforce a change in the policy of the ISP, the least we can do is be aware – for with awareness comes empowerment. Let us not forget that while advertisements give us the right to choose, we retain the prerogative to choose wisely. So the next time you see an ad, don't go rushing into the ISP's office. Rather, sign on the dotted line and go home wondering whether you made the right choice. Walk in being aware of all the possible pitfalls and loopholes, ask the right questions, and don't subscribe until you have all the necessary answers. Better still, take this article with you. **d**

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